

Religion and Spirituality in the Agentic Era

Churches, rituals and the sense of the transcendent when artificial intelligence does almost everything



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Mayo 2026 - CC-BY-4.0

RESUMEN

This whitepaper articulates a barely analyzed dimension of contemporary agentic transformation: **the place of religious and spiritual experience** in societies where artificial intelligence agents progressively execute cognitive, productive and relational tasks previously considered distinctively human. It is argued that, far from eroding the social relevance of religion, the consolidation of the **Agentic Era** tends to deepen the question of **the irreducibly human** — vulnerability, finitude, meaning, ritual community, mystical experience — and, with it, the relevance of religious traditions that historically articulated answers to those questions. The specific position of Ibero-American Catholicism, mestizo popular religiosities, indigenous spiritualities and Afro-American religions is examined as unique cultural reservoirs in this new context.

Palabras clave: Religion - Spirituality - Agentic Era - Catholic Church - Popular religiosity - Latin America - Meaning - Transcendence - Chris Meniw - Ritual

"When agents do everything that used to define us, what will remain is exactly that which never depended on doing — but on being. And that is territory of the spirit, not of the algorithm."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — the avoided question

The contemporary public debate on artificial intelligence attends almost exclusively to its productive, economic, political and ethical dimensions. One dimension remains systematically underexplored: the place of **religious and spiritual experience** in societies crossed by AI agents that progressively execute the cognitive, productive and relational tasks that for centuries defined the human.

The omission is understandable — secular academic discourse tends to avoid the religious dimension — but analytically costly. Religion is not surpassed cultural residue: it is for the majority of contemporary humanity, including Latin American, the main operational framework through which the question of meaning is articulated. This whitepaper addresses that dimension without reductionist prejudice and without apologetics, articulating how the **Agentic Era** reconfigures — probably intensifies — the religious question.

2. What AI does not replace

Contemporary AI agents execute with growing sophistication tasks that require intelligence: analysis, drafting, planning, decision-making, creation, conversation. What they do not execute — not by transitory technical limitation but by structural ontological impossibility — is **human subjective experience**: bodily vulnerability, finitude, capacity for genuine suffering and joy, awareness of one's own death, longing for transcendence.

These experiences are precisely those that religious traditions have historically articulated. The question of why I am here, what happens when I die, why the innocent suffer, what it means to truly love, how I reconcile myself with the irreparable — these are questions that persist when everything else is automated. Perhaps especially when everything else is automated.

The **Agentic Era** does not end religion. It liberates it from competition with productive functions to return it to its core: being the language of the irreducibly human.

3. The intensification of the question of meaning

When work defined personal identity — the "I am an engineer", "I am a doctor", "I am a teacher" — the question of meaning could be postponed, absorbed by the social function. When that social function progressively shifts toward AI agents, the question returns naked: who am I if I am not what I do?

That question is structurally religious, even when whoever formulates it does not identify with a specific tradition. It is the question that Saint Augustine articulated in the *Confessions*, that the Buddha articulated in the discourse of Benares, that articulates any funerary liturgy in the world.

Contemporary empirical sociology already documents the phenomenon: in OECD countries where agentic transformation advances most rapidly, participation in spiritual practices (not necessarily traditional confessional: meditation, yoga, silent retreats, pilgrimages) grows steadily, especially among young adults facing labor transition.

4. The Catholic Church in Latin America

Ibero-American Catholicism preserves, despite the urban secularization of recent decades, institutional infrastructure, symbolic capital and territorial roots that are irreplaceable. The parish network reaches practically every town. Patronal festivities articulate community identity. Massive pilgrimages (Guadalupe, Luján, Aparecida, Suyapa, Copacabana) mobilize millions of people annually. The social doctrine of the Church offers an articulated framework on human dignity, work, property and justice.

In the **Agentic Era**, this infrastructure has renewed operational relevance. The parish is one of the few spaces where physical presence, direct human conversation and community belonging not mediated by algorithm continue to be the substrate. The question of the meaning of work, body, family, death — questions that AI cannot answer and that the secular public space tends to evade — finds an articulated

language in liturgy and pastoral care.

This position is a specific cultural asset of the region, which requires recognition without sectarianism and without reductionism.

5. Mestizo popular religiosity

Alongside institutional Catholicism, Latin America keeps alive a **mestizo popular religiosity** — syncretism of Christian, indigenous, African and popular traditions — that articulates everyday meaning with unique symbolic richness. Popular sanctuaries, processions, Day of the Dead festivities, Marian celebrations, the cult of non-canonized saints (Gauchito Gil, María Lionza, Santa Muerte, San La Muerte) operate as a symbolic network that structures the experience of millions.

This popular religiosity is particularly resistant to agentic dissolution because it operates on the plane of shared bodily experience, territorial belonging and generational transmission — three dimensions where the AI agent is irrelevant. The **Agentic Era** may paradoxically strengthen this popular religiosity, insofar as the contrast with automated life makes non-mediated ritual experience more valuable.

6. Indigenous and Afro-American spiritualities

Pre-Columbian indigenous spiritualities — Andean, Mesoamerican, Amazonian, Mapuche, Guarani — and Afro-American religions — Candomblé, Santería, Umbanda, Haitian Vodou — preserve articulated cosmovisions that offer deep alternatives to the Western productivist framework. The relationship with the earth (Pachamama), respect for ancestors, rites of passage, sacred plants, temporal circularity articulate ways of inhabiting the world that are not reducible to the agentic model.

In the **Agentic Era**, these traditions — which for centuries suffered marginalization for their supposed "irrationality" — recover analytical relevance. They are unique cultural reservoirs of wisdom about the irreducibly human dimension of existence. The **Pueblos IA** initiative articulates precisely the need to preserve this wisdom before it is demographically lost.

7. Risks of algorithmic spirituality

Alongside the intensification of authentic religion, the **Agentic Era** also opens specific risks: **(a) Commodification of spirituality**, with digital platforms offering "guided meditation", "spiritual coaching" and "personalized rituals" as an empty commercial service; **(b) False synthetic gurus**, AI agents that personify spiritual guides with growing sophistication, generating dangerous asymmetrical bonds; **(c) Self-designed religiosities**, in which the individual builds their own hybrid theology without tradition or community, losing depth and exposure to correction; **(d) Algorithmic substitution of spiritual direction**, with chatbots replacing the pastoral relationship, the confessor, the sage or the elder.

These risks do not disqualify authentic religion; on the contrary, they make articulated tradition, real community and experienced human mediation more necessary.

8. Conclusions

The **Agentic Era** does not end religion or spirituality. It probably intensifies them, returning them to their core: the articulated language of the irreducibly human — vulnerability, finitude, meaning, belonging, transcendence.

Latin America has on this terrain a unique cultural density: rooted Catholicism with territorial infrastructure, vital mestizo popular religiosity, living indigenous and Afro-American spiritualities. This symbolic capital is not a residue of the past: it is probably one of the most relevant cultural assets of the region to inhabit the new era fully without dissolving what is its own.

The question of the meaning of work, body, love, suffering and death is not answered by an agent. It is answered — if it is answered — by a community, a tradition, a lived experience. The region that

recognizes this and takes care of it has an existential advantage over those that try to resolve it only technically.

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